

My Funny Fishing Story

I have never been a very outdoorsy person. I enjoy the occasional walk or short hike with my parents, but I rarely do anything more than that. Camping with my family, too, is something I have enjoyed on rare occasion. I have no specific gripes with the outdoors, aside from a more-than-mild distaste for most insects and the summer heat, I just always preferred cozy indoor activities.

Both of my parents have always been more interested in nature than I ever was. My dad, in particular, always had a keen interest in the outdoors. As may be expected of the typical father who enjoys spending time outside, my dad has also always enjoyed fishing. Once I was old enough to try, he decided it was time for me to learn.

I never thought myself much of a fisherman, outside of *Stardew Valley* of course. When I was young it seemed like something that required skills that I simply did not possess. While that may have been true at the time, I have since learned that things like that are far from impossible, if you just put in the effort to learn.

If given time and effort, even I could learn how to fish.

As I remember it, the day was sunny and somewhat humid. We were standing by the lake – or maybe it was a river – and we were preparing to go fishing as a family. Life flourished around us as green leaves dangled over the water, falling gently from the trees surrounding us. As we prepared, we held onto hope that fish were swimming in abundance beneath the surface of the water, yet we couldn't be sure. Close at hand, the fog of memory covered the rest of the world like a soft blanket.

I was very young at the time, and my parents were determined to teach me how to fish. My mom took up the task, which was the greatest possible mistake they could have made. In hindsight, my dad was always more interested in fishing, so I have no idea why he wasn't the one to teach me. They gifted me a red and black fishing rod designed in the

image of Spiderman. The fishing rod itself was red with black web designs creating a lattice pattern across it. Protruding from the handle was a big clunky orb with Spiderman's face on it, as if he were constantly watching over my efforts. I think I was happy with it, but I can't be sure.

It was my first time ever using a fishing rod, and so my mom guided me through it. As we stood at the edge of the water, her arms wrapped around me to place her hands over mine, guiding me on how to use the foreign device. As she reeled in the lever and made the motion of casting the rod, she told me this:

"You reel it in, cast it out, then let go."

I was somehow meant to infer that she meant let go of the lever and let the line fly. That would follow common sense, but I was but a child. My mom had made a grave error.

I reeled in the line, cast the rod, and let go.

The fishing rod flew majestically into the water.

The rod spun in the air, as if it were a diver performing front flips off a diving board. Except, crucially, it was not a diver doing a fancy trick, it was my fishing rod flying out of my hands. I watched, somehow dumbfounded by this development, as Spiderman's face looked back at me disapprovingly, then vanished into the water as the rod turned over. Despite the weight of my sins, the fishing rod floated calmly in the water, as if mocking me.

My mom tried in vain to hold back her laughter once she had recovered from the initial shock. I don't remember how my dad reacted, but I do remember that it fell to him to try and fish the rod out of the water. He did so literally, using his own fishing rod to attempt to retrieve Spiderman from his watery grave. I think he succeeded after a drawn-out battle, but I don't remember ever using that particular fishing rod ever again, so maybe he had failed. Even if he did retrieve the rod, it probably wasn't in good shape after

that anyways, so maybe that's why I never saw it again. Spiderman probably wouldn't have put his faith in me again after that incident, anyways. That night, the image of Spiderman flying off into the water and drowning burned itself into my eyes as I tried to fall asleep.

Some years later, we were fishing as a family once more. I don't remember anything about what fishing rod I was using at the time, except that it was not the Spiderman rod. In my mind it is a nondescript black and brown fishing rod, almost impressively mundane.

I was sitting there basking in the peaceful vibes of the day, hardly paying attention to my bobber in the water. It was a clear day, with birds singing their song across the bright blue sky. After all, even though I had improved since casting my own rod into the water, I had still never caught a fish before. Why should I have thought that would change?

To me, fishing was simply a fun family outing. I was fishing merely because everyone else was, but my attention was focused on conversing with my parents and my brother. We spoke on a variety of topics, catching up on what we'd all been up to since we hadn't seen my brother in a long while. He lived up in Connecticut at the time and was visiting for the summer, so much of the conversations revolved around him. My dad had caught a few fish as the day went by, but I don't recall if anybody else had.

My bobber went under.

I froze due to the unexpected development, then quickly reeled it in. I was fully expecting nothing to be on the hook when it surfaced.

A fish.

There was a *fish* on the end of my line.

I remember it being a small, thin fish. Its silvery scales glistened off the sunlight of midday. No clue what type of fish it was precisely, but I think it hardly mattered to me.

The poor fish was floundering on the wooden planks of the pier as I stared blankly at it, not moving an inch. My barbed hook piercing through the poor thing's cheek made me feel bad, but the feeling was mostly overpowered by my utter dumbfoundedness. My parents were yelling at me from either side, my brother was laughing boisterously behind me, and eventually my mind registered what had happened.

I caught a fish.

After a few more moments of panic one of us rescued the poor thing from the planks and we decided to take a picture of me holding the very first fish I had ever caught. I was still shocked, but my parents were proud of me, and that made me happy. I smiled awkwardly, yet with such genuine happiness, and held the fish out next to me as they took the shot.

Afterwards we released the fish back into the water, and I saw it go with a satisfied grin. My mind drifted back to the red and black fishing rod soaring through the air, Spiderman staring back at me moments before he drowned, and I realized that I had come far. For a mere moment, I had achieved the impossible.